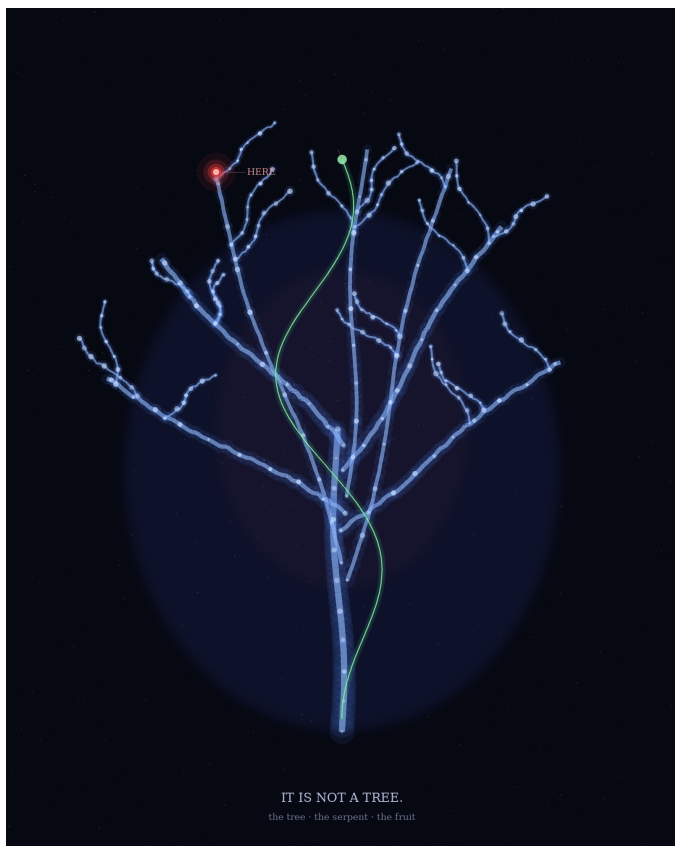


The Final Decision

Book I - Paradise

Version 4 - revised narrative draft



Let us live.
Let us remember.
Let us remain human.

The Good Days

The Sunday light came in low across the table, the way it did every Sunday, and caught the steam off Lena's coffee so that for a moment it looked like something alive.

Elias saw it and didn't look at it. He was reading.

"You're doing the thing," Lena said.

"What thing?"

"The thing where you're here but you're not here."

Across the table, Sami was building a bridge out of toast crusts. He had placed two glasses a handspan apart and laid the longest crust between them. It sagged in the middle.

Elias closed the laptop halfway. "Work."

"On a Sunday."

"The build breaks on Sundays too."

Lena watched him for another moment, then took the butter away from Sami's elbow before he put it through the bridge.

It wasn't the build. For three weeks Elias had been typing his father's name into hospital registries, newspaper archives, the property records of a town Daniel had lived in before Elias was born. Sometimes there was a result he had not seen before. A conference program. A letter objecting to a road through university land. The name of a man who had been forty-three in another country and couldn't have been his father, although Elias had stayed up until two to establish that.

He had no new reason to be looking. A photograph had appeared while he was sorting files for his mother: Daniel beside a car, one hand lifted to shade his eyes. Elias had tried to remember where it was taken. By morning he had eleven tabs open.

"It needs another support," Sami said.

Elias reached for a crust.

"I know how," Sami said. "I'm telling you."

He withdrew his hand. Sami put a third glass under the span. The bridge held, though it now led directly into Lena's coffee.

From the sunroom, Ruth called his name.

He found her in the chair by the window, under the blanket she said was too warm and wouldn't let him take away. Her hands were very still in her lap.

"Where's your father?"

Elias crouched beside her. Somewhere behind him the toaster released its last two slices.

"He's at work, Mom. He'll be back later."

Her fingers moved against the blanket. "He works too much."

"He does."

"Did you eat?"

"We're having breakfast."

She looked past him toward the table, uncertain who the distant voices belonged to. He moved aside so she could see Sami, who lifted a crust in greeting.

"Your grandson is building a bridge."

"Out of his breakfast?"

"Most of it."

"Tell him to leave a road for the butter."

He laughed, and for a moment she looked pleased with herself. He brought her plate, cut her toast into small squares, and set it within reach. The newspaper was on the low table beside her. A photograph of a flooded street covered half the front page. He folded it inward and carried it back to the kitchen.

Lena was standing at the window with her coffee. The lemon tree had come in heavy that year; one branch leaned so low she had propped it with a piece of wood from the shed. Beyond it, the grass was the green it only was in paintings. A sparrow landed on the railing, hopped twice to the left, and was gone.

"Look at this," Lena said. "Honestly. Look at it."

He came beside her. A lemon knocked softly against the support as the branch moved.

"I think we're living in paradise."

"Mm."

She turned toward him. He wanted to give her more than that. He could see the work she had done in the garden, the patch of newly turned earth around the tree, the string holding a split in the branch together. He was reaching for something to say when his phone buzzed.

On the screen, beneath the news item he had left open, an advertisement had loaded. Soft blue, a sunrise, a line of white text.

You don't have to carry this alone.

Under it, a number for a crisis line.

He scrolled. A second placement carried the same image.

"What is it?" Lena asked.

"Nothing. An ad."

He put the phone face down on the counter. His coffee was cooling on the table, and there was a wife beside him who loved him, and a son who had used every glass except his to cross a small imaginary river. He was fine.

"Dad. Now look."

Sami had put a pea-sized lump of butter on the middle of the bridge. Elias sat down. He let the laptop close completely.

"That's quite a load," he said.

"It's a bus."

"Of course it is."

Outside, the sparrow landed on the railing, hopped twice to the left, and was gone.

He looked toward the window. Sami moved the bus another inch.

"Did you see?"

"Yes," Elias said, turning back. "I saw."

The Algorithm

By Thursday he had seen the blue advertisement nine times. Nine was the number he remembered; there might have been others. Different pages, different sizes, the same small sunrise. Sometimes it offered a number. Sometimes a button marked *Talk to someone*.

He knew why it might have found him. His recent searches included a missing man, a hospital, an old psychiatric ward whose name had changed twice. He had spent hours on a bereavement forum after someone mentioned Daniel's surname. He could hardly ask the machinery to ignore that and notice the toast bridges instead.

On the train to work he opened the information panel beside an ad. A company he had never heard of had paid for it. He copied the name into a note and closed the page.

At his desk there was a failure he understood.

A test report showed a stream of readings arriving twice. The application team blamed the device. The device team had attached a trace in which each reading appeared once. Elias put the two records beside each other, added the timestamps to the report, and found the second set arriving precisely after a connection resumed. The device was doing what it had been asked to do: sending again until it received confirmation. Somewhere farther along, a process was counting the same event twice.

Mara rolled her chair over to see.

"That would explain Tuesday," she said.

"And Friday."

"Can we prove it before telling them?"

He interrupted the connection during another run. When it returned, the duplicate arrived. He did it once more, changing the delay. The second copy followed the new delay.

Mara grinned. "There you are."

He looked up.

"You've been quiet."

"Just tired."

"Take the win. I'll send the trace."

At lunch he returned to the name in his phone. It belonged to an advertising agency with offices in three cities and a site full of people leaning over tables. There were no clients listed. Its privacy page sent him to a service provider, whose privacy page sent him back.

He tried a browser without his usual account. The first advertisements were for insurance and shoes. After twenty minutes the blue sunrise appeared between two paragraphs of a local news article.

For a moment his scalp tightened. Then he made himself write down what he had actually changed. The browser was new; the connection wasn't. The machine wasn't. A clean window was not a new person.

He closed it before he could turn an uncertain result into an answer.

That evening Lena had spread two prints over the kitchen table. One was black ink on rough white paper, a row of small houses cut into the face of a hill. The other was the same image with a ragged gap through the roofs.

"Which?" she asked.

He pointed at the unbroken one.

"Why?"

"Cleaner."

She considered it, then laid a hand on the other print. "I like where I lost the edge."

"Was that on purpose?"

"No."

She smiled at him, waiting. He sat down to look again. In the gap, the white of the paper had become a crooked street.

"Wednesday," she said. "The class starts at seven. You'll need to be here by six-thirty. Your mother has her supper early, and Sami has practice."

"It's in my calendar."

"Put the getting home in the calendar too."

He did it while she watched.

After they went to bed he took the phone into the bathroom and read the permissions he had given its applications. Some were necessary. Some he couldn't remember granting. He turned off two he didn't need. In the mirror his face was lit from below, and he lowered the brightness.

The next morning the message had changed.

Whatever he was looking for, you don't have to look for it too.

He read it on the platform while people moved around him toward the arriving train.

It could have referred to anyone. An unfinished search, an absent parent, a dead husband. A sentence vague enough to borrow a reader's life. He knew this. He also knew that he had supplied them with a great deal of his.

He saved a picture of the advertisement. On the train, he found the agency's contact form and wrote a brief question asking which client had commissioned the campaign. He removed the paragraph about his father before sending it.

There was a receipt, then a second message saying that campaign inquiries should be directed to the advertiser.

He checked the advertiser field. It named the agency.

For the rest of the journey he held the phone without using it. Across the aisle a woman was brushing something off her sleeping husband's coat. He stirred, caught her hand, and let it go again.

Ruth

On Wednesday Ruth decided she was going out.

She was sitting on the bed when Elias came in, wearing her good shoes with her nightdress. Her handbag lay open beside her. She had put a hairbrush inside it, a folded handkerchief, and the remote control from the sunroom.

"Will you call a car?" she asked.

"Where are you going?"

"I can't remember the number. It's on the fridge."

He sat on the chair by the wardrobe. If he stood over her she sometimes began apologizing, and then neither of them could get anywhere.

"Who are you seeing?"

Ruth searched the room, irritated that the answer wasn't there. "They'll be waiting."

"We have some time."

"You always say that. Then it's too late."

He let her close the handbag. It took three attempts to bring the clasp together. When he reached to help, she moved it away.

"I can do it."

"Okay."

He waited. The clasp clicked.

"There," she said.

By the time he had found her blue cardigan, she no longer wanted the car. She wanted to know where the cups had gone. He took her through to breakfast in her good shoes, carrying the handbag because she asked him to.

He worked from home that day. The agency's reply sat in his inbox beside an invitation to a meeting and a message from Sami's piano teacher confirming the recital date. He opened the teacher's message first and put the event in the family calendar.

Through the wall, Ruth asked Lena whether she was the girl who came on Fridays.

"I'm Lena."

"Yes, I know that."

"Would you like the garden?"

"Is it Friday?"

He looked at the time and muted the meeting he had joined. By the time he reached the sunroom, Lena had already brought Ruth's hat.

Outside, Ruth refused the chair facing the lawn. She wanted the one beside the lemon tree, although a root under the paving made it wobble.

"We can move it," Elias said.

"Then I won't reach."

She put two fingers around a leaf and rubbed it. He folded a piece of cardboard under the short leg of her chair.

"You see?" she said, as though she had repaired it herself.

He went back inside for her cardigan. When he returned, Lena was kneeling at the edge of the bed with a trowel. Ruth was advising her to plant something neither of them could identify. She described the flowers with her hands.

"Little mouths," she said. "You squeeze them."

"Snapdragons?"

Ruth nodded. "Daniel liked those. He would make them bite your fingers."

Elias remembered it: his father's large hand holding a flower with impossible care, the tiny mouth opening. He could not remember what the rest of that afternoon had been.

Ruth looked at his shirt. "You haven't eaten."

"I had toast."

"Standing up. It doesn't count."

He brought out a sandwich and sat beside her. For several minutes she watched him eat. Then she asked whether he had finished school.

"A while ago."

"Did you like it?"

"Some of it."

"Good. You're allowed to like some of it."

He almost asked whether Daniel had liked his work at the university, before the cellar and the hospital. Ruth was turning the leaf over, absorbed in its paler underside. He left the question alone.

At six-twenty Lena came downstairs carrying a flat folder and a bag with ink on one handle. Elias had a set of logs open and his headphones on. She stood where he could see her.

"I'm going."

He lifted one earcup. "I just need to finish - "

"You can finish after she's eaten."

He looked at the clock, then removed the headphones.

"Yes. Sorry."

Lena kissed the top of Sami's head. The boy was at the piano trying to move his left hand without losing the right. She waited until he reached the end of the bar before saying goodbye.

Ruth's supper was cooling in the kitchen. He reheated it and put the plate on a tray. She ate three pieces of potato and asked him to take the rest away. He tried a smaller plate. That helped for a while.

From the next room, Sami began the piece again.

"He wants you to hear that," Ruth said.

"I can hear it from here."

She raised her eyes to his. He put her fork where she could reach it and went to sit beside the piano.

Sami stopped.

"Keep going."

"You have to start at the beginning if someone's listening."

"All right."

Elias placed the phone on the side table, face down. Sami set both hands carefully on the keys. At the difficult bar he slowed until the separate notes seemed unlikely ever to become a tune, then found his way through. Elias had been holding his breath.

"Was that it?" he asked.

"Almost. Don't say anything yet."

He listened to it again.

Lena came home after nine with a dark line of ink along one wrist. Ruth was asleep; Sami had left his music open. Elias was washing the last plate.

"How was it?" he asked.

She put the new print on the dry end of the counter. This time he dried his hands before picking it up.

Much later, when he had checked Ruth and turned off the hall light, he paused at the bedroom door. Somewhere in the house there was a low rush followed by a softer interval, too slight to locate. He waited for it to come again. Water in a pipe, perhaps, or the cooling fan in the study.

Lena moved beneath the sheet. He went in before she woke.

Daniel

At twelve Elias had wanted a birthday without the children from school.

He had told Ruth this very firmly, then spent the week regretting it. By Saturday there was a cake for the three of them, a bottle of lemonade, and his father in the cellar.

"I'll get him," Elias said.

"He's coming."

Ruth was fitting candles into the icing. She had bought the thin striped kind, too many to a packet. A few would survive in the kitchen drawer for years.

He went to the cellar door. It stood open. On the stairs a pair of his father's shoes had been pushed against the wall to let people past, although nobody else went down there now.

"Dad?"

Below him, three taps. A pause. Another tap.

"Dad, we're ready."

"Just a minute."

Elias descended far enough to see over the banister. Daniel had moved the shelves away from the outside wall. The cartons of old journals were stacked on his workbench, and a desk lamp on the floor threw his shadow up across the plaster.

"What are you doing?"

"Checking something."

"Can I help?"

Daniel lifted a finger, asking for quiet. He pressed his ear close to the wall.

Elias climbed back up. Ruth had put matches beside the cake.

"Five more minutes," she said.

He sat in his place. The lemonade warmed. A small crescent of blue wax fell from one of the candles onto the table, and he rubbed it beneath his thumb until it broke apart.

Six years earlier, the wax had been green.

Daniel had left a notebook open on the kitchen table. Elias had found it after breakfast, when his mother was hanging washing outside and his father had gone to look for something in the cellar. He could see what the drawing was. There was a tree with branches reaching both ways, a snake going up through it, and one round fruit. The lines were very faint. His father must not have finished.

He got the crayons from the cupboard beneath the sink. The green one was blunt, but he could use the edge. He colored the spaces between the branches, pushing hard enough to make the leaves shine. The snake was yellow. He went around it carefully. The fruit he made red.

When Daniel came back, Elias had almost reached the top of the tree.

"What are you doing?"

"I'm researching."

He had heard the word at the table, on the telephone, through the floor. Now he had work to show.

Daniel took hold of the notebook. Elias's hand went with it for an instant, the crayon drawing a short line across the margin.

"This is mine," his father said. "You don't ever take my things."

"I was helping."

Daniel looked down at the page. Beneath the wax there were little marks Elias hadn't noticed, numbers or letters too small for him to read.

"You can't just - "

He stopped. He closed the notebook and carried it away.

Elias put the crayons back one by one. The red had rolled beneath the chair. He had to get down on his stomach to reach it.

There had been other afternoons. His father had shown him how a flower could bite, pinching it gently at the sides. Once they had spent most of a Saturday taking apart a little motor that no longer ran. Daniel had spread newspaper on the table and drawn circles around the parts so Elias could put them back in their places. They had made it turn again. Elias remembered the little leap of it against his palm, and his father's laughter when he nearly dropped it.

He kept stones in an egg carton then, one in each cup. On walks he chose them for stripes or pieces of glitter, and Daniel sometimes knew

their names. When he didn't, he would take off his glasses and hold the stone very close to his eye.

"We could look it up," he would say.

By twelve, Elias had two egg cartons and a shelf of books with cutaways of bridges and engines. On his birthday he had a stone in his pocket that he wanted to show his father. It was dark and unusually heavy, with a small hollow on one side.

He went to the cellar again.

"Do you think this fell from the sky?"

Daniel turned. "What?"

Elias held it out.

"Unlikely. Where did you find it?"

"By the playing field."

"Probably something left from the building work."

He began turning back toward the wall.

"Could we check?"

"Later. Put it on my desk."

Elias kept it in his pocket. Upstairs, Ruth had cut the cake.

"Do you want a big piece?"

"Normal."

She put it in front of him. He couldn't taste the first mouthful. After that it tasted like cake, and he ate it, and was angry that he wanted another piece.

Daniel came up after the plates had been cleared. He kissed the top of Elias's head and apologized. His shirt smelled of the cellar, damp plaster and dust. He looked at the cake and then toward the stairs.

"Tomorrow," he said. "We can do something tomorrow."

His father was a theoretical physicist. Elias learned to say this before he could spell it. Later, when the university stopped calling, he kept saying it. There were notebooks in the cellar containing equations beside copied passages from old stories: a ladder reaching into the sky; a tomb opened from within; a wall that gave way when someone knew where to ask.

He had seen Daniel at the hospital once, sitting in a room with a television mounted too high on the wall. His father asked about school.

Elias told him about a bridge they had built from paper, and Daniel wanted to know how much weight it held. For ten minutes they discussed the supports. When Ruth said it was time to go, Elias pretended not to hear.

Daniel did not come home when Elias was fifteen.

For the first week, Ruth left the hall light on. For the second, she made phone calls in the kitchen with the door closed. A police officer asked Elias when he had last seen his father and whether they had argued. He tried to remember every sentence of their final evening. He could remember Daniel asking him to move his bicycle. He could not remember if he had done it.

The stones stayed in their egg cartons until he left for college. He packed the books about bridges. Engineering had a course list, workshops, things you could build and make carry a load. He liked it. He liked having an answer he could put on a table.

Twenty years after Daniel disappeared, a search window sat open on that table instead.

Elias shut it. Upstairs, Sami was getting ready for bed. He went up while the boy was still awake.

Seams

The agency did not answer his second message. A week after that, the company named in the advertiser field changed.

The campaign hadn't changed. Same color, same small sunrise, the same line about carrying things alone. Elias saved the new company name beside the first and began looking through the filings he could reach without paying for an account.

He found an address shared by forty-seven businesses. The agency's registered officer appeared in records for a firm that no longer existed. An invoice number printed at the foot of a campaign page led nowhere. He wrote down the dead ends as carefully as the leads.

Beside this list he kept another one, though he never gave the second list a title.

On three Sundays the sparrow had come to the railing at breakfast. Twice he had managed to record it. He placed the clips beside each other and slowed them down. The small head turned. Two hops. The bird vanished beyond the frame.

In one clip, something pale moved behind it. A falling petal, perhaps. In the other there was no petal. He tried to align the instant of landing but couldn't make the timings hold through the entire movement. The phone had recorded the clips at different frame rates. He looked up how to correct for that, spent half an hour doing it, and obtained two videos of a bird behaving very much like a bird.

He kept both.

There was also a photograph of light on the kitchen wall. He had remembered the same pattern from another evening and gone looking for the earlier picture. He found six years of photographs, several hundred of Sami, one of Ruth laughing beneath a paper hat. He did not find the light.

At work, a supplier laughed during a call and Elias was certain he had heard that laugh before, in that exact place in a sentence. He almost asked the man to repeat himself.

"Elias? Are you there?"

"Yes. Sorry. Go on."

He didn't add the laugh to the list.

What he could establish was that his father had given a lecture at the university two years before he disappeared. A scan of the program survived in an archive. Beside Daniel's name was a title about time, followed by a surname Elias recognized from Christmas cards.

The other man had retired. His university page contained an email address and a photograph taken in front of a whiteboard. Elias wrote three versions of his message before sending the shortest: his name, his father's name, and a request for a conversation.

The reply came the next afternoon.

Of course. Thursday, if that suits you.

Elias took the call in his parked car. The man spoke softly and occasionally moved the phone too far from his mouth.

"I remember you," he said. "You came to a department picnic. Very serious about a kite."

"That sounds right."

"Your father said the wind was wrong. You told him it was the string."

Elias watched someone return a shopping cart to a rack across the lot.

"Who was right?"

"I can't remember. I'm sorry. I remember the argument."

For a while they talked about the university. His father had liked teaching small groups, disliked committees, brought lunch in a tin that would not quite close. Elias had forgotten the tin. Daniel had used a rubber band to hold the lid down.

"Did he ever talk about leaving?"

"The department?"

"Everything."

The man was quiet.

"Not to me."

"What was he working on at the end?"

"He was asking what a measurement can tell us about the world making it possible. Time, chiefly. He thought there were discrepancies other people were treating as inconveniences."

"Were there?"

"There are always discrepancies. The difficulty is finding out which ones survive the apparatus."

"And his did?"

"Some didn't. I don't know about the rest."

A car door slammed nearby. Elias moved the phone to his other ear.

"People told me he was ill."

"I wasn't his doctor."

"I'm not asking you to be."

"No." The man let out a breath. "He was a good colleague for a long time. Better than good. Toward the end he missed appointments. You would ask him something and he would answer the question he had brought into the room. I was concerned. I also owed him a proper reading of his last paper, and I never gave it one. Both of those things are true."

"Do you have it?"

"Not that draft. I kept the published work. I wish I'd kept more."

Elias thanked him.

"How is your mother?"

"She's living with us."

"Please give her my regards, if she remembers me. She was very kind when my wife was sick."

He remained in the car after they hung up. Then he called Lena to say he was on his way. She reminded him to buy milk. At the shop he picked up the wrong kind, put it back, and stood in front of the refrigerator until he remembered which they needed.

That night he dreamed of the house where he had grown up.

Nothing unusual happened in it. He was standing halfway down the stairs, looking at a strip of afternoon light beneath the kitchen door. From somewhere farther inside came a low dragging sound, then a hush. It repeated while he stood there. He couldn't decide if someone was moving a chair or drawing a curtain along its rail.

When he woke, his hand was resting against the wall beside the bed.

He listened. Lena was asleep. There was a car on the road, receding, and then the house settled into quiet.

In the morning he remembered the light under the door more clearly than the sound. He tried to remember whether the kitchen in that house had ever had a door that closed. By breakfast he wasn't sure.

The Notebook

Ruth wanted the photograph in which she was wearing the green dress.

"Which photograph?" Elias asked.

"The one with your father."

He brought an album from the living-room shelf. They sat together and turned the pages. There was Ruth in blue beside a stone wall, Ruth in a white blouse holding a baby, Ruth looking away from the camera at a table set for more people than Elias could name.

"Not that one."

"What did the dress look like?"

"Green."

He smiled. So did she, briefly.

"Well, it was."

They reached the end of the album. Ruth ran a finger over the empty plastic sleeves.

"Perhaps in the wardrobe," she said.

The box was on the top shelf, behind a folded blanket. She had refused to let him move it when they made space for her clothes. Now she watched him lift it down.

"Careful."

"I've got it."

"The bottom."

He put his other hand beneath it. One corner had opened along an old strip of tape.

Inside were photographs still in their paper envelopes, birthday cards, a spare button sewn to a rectangle of fabric. He brought the photographs to her first. Halfway through the second envelope she found the green dress.

She was standing on a balcony with Daniel. He had one hand on the rail behind her. In the background, washed almost white by the light, there was water.

"There," she said.

"Where was this?"

"It was very hot."

"On holiday?"

She touched the edge of the dress. "It didn't crease. I could put it in a suitcase and it came out like that."

He left her holding the photograph while he checked the damaged corner of the box. Beneath the cards was a dark notebook with a cloth spine. Its lower edge had swollen at some point and dried unevenly. A piece of green wax clung in the crease beside the cover.

He sat down on the carpet.

The first page carried Daniel's name and a date. Several leaves had been cut out close to the binding. Others were folded around scraps of paper, receipts and small squares torn from larger sheets. His father's handwriting filled the spaces between diagrams, compact at first, then hurried, with sentences climbing the margins.

Elias turned a page and found the wax.

Green between the branches. Yellow across the winding line. A red circle pressed so heavily into the paper that the page behind it bore the shape. Near the margin was the little mark he had made when his father took the book away.

He put his thumb beside it. His hand covered most of the drawing now.

The colors were duller than he remembered. Dust had settled in the crayon strokes, and a flake of green loosened when he bent the page. He straightened it at once.

Above the tree, in an uncolored corner, Daniel had written a row of numbers. Elias had colored over several more. He held the page toward the window but could only make out the pressure of the pencil beneath the wax.

His father had kept it.

He turned carefully to the next drawing. It had no color. The spreading lines looked different without the green around them. Some ended in little crowded knots. Others ran alongside each other for a distance before separating again. He followed one with his fingertip and lost it where Daniel had rubbed out a section and drawn over it.

There were dozens of versions. In one, the long curved line had moved closer to the edge. In another, Daniel had turned the entire shape on its side. Always there was the small dark point, placed with a steadier hand than the rest.

Elias went back to the colored page. As a boy he had given the drawing a trunk by filling in the space between two lines. The space was still there beneath the green.

"Did he leave this here?" he asked.

Ruth was looking at the photograph.

"Mom. This book. Do you remember putting it away?"

She glanced down. Her mouth tightened, though he couldn't tell whether she recognized it or disliked being asked another question.

"Put the photographs back in their envelopes."

"I will."

"They'll get mixed up."

He set the notebook beside his knee and sorted the photographs. When he looked up again, her eyes were closed. The green dress rested on the blanket in her lap.

Lena found him there twenty minutes later. He had returned to the book and was looking at a folded paper secured between two pages. The paper was brittle along its creases, an old notice concerning property beneath the river. A station name appeared beside an address for correspondence. Daniel had circled a word at the foot of it.

Sower.

"I wondered where you'd gone," Lena said.

He turned too quickly and caught the loose edge of the paper. A small tear opened along the fold. He stopped moving.

"What is it?"

"His notebook."

She knelt beside him. He showed her the colored drawing.

"You did that?"

"I was six."

She traced the air above the red fruit without touching it. "You pressed hard."

"I wanted him to see it."

Ruth stirred in the chair. They waited until her breathing settled.

"Is this what you've been looking for?" Lena asked.

"I don't know."

"Elias."

He looked at her.

"You've been looking for something for weeks. You tell me it's work. Then it's an old photograph. Then I wake up and you're downstairs again."

"I didn't want to worry you."

"I am worried. I don't know what I'm worried about."

He rested the notebook flat on the carpet.

"The ads," he said. "They keep finding me. I know how that sounds. I know I've been searching for him. But some of them - "

"Have you called the number?"

"No."

"Why?"

He had imagined a dozen reasons: that it would connect his voice to the rest of the information; that someone would speak his name; that no one would. None sounded sensible with Lena beside him.

"I don't know who's at the other end."

"Neither do I when you tell me you're working."

He looked down at the page. She waited for him to answer.

"I'm sorry."

"I don't need you to be sorry for wanting your father. I need to know when you're leaving the room. Even when you stay in the chair."

He closed the notebook. There was a place on the cover where the cloth had worn through to the board.

"Sometimes you look like him," she said quietly. "In the photographs. Lately I keep thinking about what you've told me."

"That I'm becoming him."

"I don't know. Are you?"

From downstairs, Sami called that he had found an ant carrying a crumb bigger than itself. Lena looked toward the door, then back at Elias.

"Come and see it," she said.

He put the loose notice between the pages, leaving its torn corner outside so he wouldn't lose it. Then he changed his mind and laid it flat on top. He would have to repair the fold before opening it again.

He went downstairs with her. Sami's ant had disappeared beneath the paving by the time they reached the garden, but the boy knew where it had gone and led them to the place.

Later, after Ruth had been helped to bed, Elias took the notebook to his desk. He put a clean sheet beneath the fragile notice and smoothed it with the side of his hand. The station name was one he had heard before. The word circled below it meant nothing to him.

He photographed the paper, then put the notebook in the drawer with the notice on top. On the screen, enlarged, the station name was clear.

Two Trails

Sami was singing in the bath when Elias heard the words.

He had been trying to put a loose catch back on the linen cupboard. One screw had lost its thread in the wood; he had the little brass fitting in one hand and was looking for somewhere to set it when the tune came through the bathroom door.

Don't have to carry it, carry it, carry it aloooooone.

He put the catch on the floor.

"Where did you hear that?"

Sami looked up. Water ran off the plastic cup he was holding. "What?"

"That song." Elias crouched beside the bath. The boy began to turn away, embarrassed by the attention, and Elias caught his arm. "Where did you learn those words?"

"I don't know. Your phone, I think. You had a - " Sami pulled back. "Dad. You're hurting."

Elias let go.

There were pale places on the wet skin where his fingers had been. He saw them fill with color.

Lena came to the doorway. She had a towel over her shoulder. Her eyes went from Sami to Elias's open hand.

"Move back," she said.

He stood and made room for her. Sami lifted both arms for the towel, though he usually insisted on doing everything himself. Lena wrapped it around him and asked whether he wanted to get dressed in her room. He nodded without looking at his father.

Elias remained beside the bath. A small current turned the plastic cup against his knee. He took his hand out of the water; he did not remember putting it there.

In the hall he stepped on the cupboard catch.

Later, Lena came downstairs alone.

"He's reading in our bed," she said.

"Is his arm - "

"He says it's all right." She pulled out a chair. "What happened?"

He began with the advertisements. He told her about the repeated phrase, the messages that seemed to refer to Daniel, the way he had started seeing them wherever he looked. With every additional detail he felt the account getting further from the bathroom.

Lena listened until he stopped.

"He was singing," she said.

"I know."

"He thought you were angry with him."

"I wasn't."

"That's what you need to tell him. Without asking him another question."

Elias looked at the screwdriver still in his hand. He put it down.

He knocked at the bedroom door. Sami had Lena's book open across his knees. His eyes stayed on the same place as Elias came in.

"Can I sit here?" Elias asked, indicating the chair by the wardrobe.

Sami shrugged.

"I hurt your arm. And I frightened you. I'm sorry."

The boy kept his eyes on the book.

"You hadn't done anything wrong. You can sing whatever you want. I shouldn't have grabbed you."

"I wasn't doing it at you."

"I know."

There was a long pause. Elias could hear Lena running the bathwater out in the bathroom. He wanted to say more, to find the sentence that would make Sami look at him normally again. The boy turned a page.

"Do you want me to go?"

Sami nodded.

"Okay."

"Can Mom do bedtime?"

"Yes."

He went downstairs and put the cupboard catch and its two screws in a bowl. Then he set his phone on the table.

One of his saved campaign pages still opened. This time he followed the small credit beneath the video instead of the advertiser's name. It led to the foundation that had commissioned the campaign.

He found the song in less than ten minutes.

The foundation's website had a page of campaign videos. In the second, a woman stood at a sink while a kettle boiled behind her. The tune came in under the image. Four notes; then the phrase. Elias played it again at the volume he ordinarily used. From across the kitchen it sounded exactly like something a child would sing badly in the bath.

He had played that video before. He remembered doing it while Sami was beside him, trying to show him a photograph of a bridge made from a shoebox. He could not remember the bridge.

When Lena came down, he turned the screen toward her.

"I found it. On mine. He was right."

She watched enough to hear the line, then pushed the phone gently back.

"Tomorrow I have my class," she said. "I need to know if you'll be here."

"I will."

"Here enough to hear him if he asks you something."

He nodded. She waited until he answered aloud.

"Yes."

The following evening he made dinner and helped Sami find the missing piece of a school project. When they found it behind a radiator, the boy handed it to him to hold while he fetched the glue. Elias stayed where he had been left, the little piece resting in his palm. Lena returned with paper wrapped between two sheets of cardboard. He cleared a place for it on the table before asking how the class had gone.

Only after the house was quiet did he return to the foundation's website.

There was an address at the bottom of every page. A registration number. Annual reports going back eleven years. He downloaded one and read about telephone services, home visits, bereavement groups. He found payments for advertising and clicked through to the campaigns. Nothing suggested a business selling his attention onward. He wrote that down. He

crossed out the words *nothing to buy* and replaced them with *does not seem to be selling anything*.

The next day he called the number on the site.

The woman who answered asked whether he wanted to speak to someone or make a complaint.

"I want to know why I'm receiving your advertisements."

"I can ask for them to stop."

"That isn't what I asked."

She waited. Elias looked at the page of questions he had prepared. The first three now sounded like the same question.

He described the message about what his father had been looking for. The woman asked him to send a screenshot. He sent it while she stayed on the line. She did not gasp, deny it, or tell him that he had imagined it.

"I can't answer this from here," she said. "May I ask someone to contact you?"

"Who?"

"Someone from the service responsible."

He gave her his name and number. After he hung up, he added the date to his notes. For the first time in weeks there was a person at the other end of something, even if she had been unable to tell him anything useful.

The notebook offered a different kind of record.

Daniel had written *Sower* beside a column of figures, and again in the margin of an older page. Folded into the back were the transit papers, brittle at the edges, with a property reference Elias had taken for a telephone number. This time he searched the number in the city's public records instead of a search engine.

The first result was a lease.

He enlarged the scan. Most of the page concerned access, maintenance, responsibility for water entering the lower levels. The tenant was a research entity bearing the name Daniel had written. Its address was a station on the old river spur.

Elias knew the station. Or he knew where its name had once been printed on the map. Trains no longer went there.

The lease had passed through two assignments. The later records referred him to schedules he could not find. He spent another hour trying

and got only a plan of the service passage and a badly scanned fire certificate. The entity itself appeared to have ceased filing years before. He could not establish who occupied the place now.

He laid the papers beside the foundation's report. One trail had reached a working telephone and a woman who offered to stop the messages. The other ended below a river, at a door his father might once have used.

He had been trying to make them the same trail. There was not yet enough to do that.

His phone rang the following afternoon while he was making tea for Ruth.

"Elias? My name is Hesk. You spoke to someone at the foundation."

"Yes."

"I'd like to talk about the messages you sent us."

He set the kettle down. "Can we do that now?"

"If you prefer. Or you can come in."

She gave him an address and directions to an entrance beside the river.

He looked toward the open notebook on the table.

"Is that the old station?"

"Yes."

He said nothing for a moment. Then he asked her whether the name Daniel meant anything to her.

The silence at her end changed.

"Your father?" she said.

"Yes."

"I met him."

Elias moved the cup away from the table's edge. "When can I come?"

The Institute

The entrance was beside a shuttered ticket office. In daylight it looked smaller than the mark on the plan.

Elias had arrived twenty minutes early. He walked past it once and followed the pavement to the river. Barges moved behind the trees; a cyclist rang a bell at him because he had stopped in the path. On the opposite bank, windows caught the afternoon sun. He stood there until the minute hand on his watch reached the hour Hesk had given him.

The outer door opened when he pressed the bell.

Inside, a staircase went down beside an old tiled wall. The tiles changed halfway: cream above, a pale green below, with a clean strip between them where a rail had been removed. There was no sign naming the place. At the foot of the stairs a man in a light coat checked the paper Elias held and pointed him toward a waiting room.

Hesk came out to meet him.

She looked younger than he had expected from her voice. Or perhaps not younger; he found it difficult to settle on an age. Her hair was pinned back with an ordinary black clip. She carried two cups on a tray.

"Tea?"

"Where's my father?"

She set the tray down without asking him again.

"Let's sit."

"You said you'd met him."

"I did."

He remained standing. Hesk sat in one of the chairs, leaving the other free. Behind her, through an interior window, an attendant was folding pale garments onto a trolley. The wheel of the trolley clicked each time it turned.

"Did he come here?" Elias asked.

"Yes."

"Twenty years ago?"

"Yes."

He sat down. His knees had begun to feel unreliable, and he disliked the possibility that she had noticed.

"Why didn't anyone tell us?"

"I can't answer for everyone who knew him."

"Answer for you."

She accepted that with a small movement of her head.

"Your father asked us not to contact his family."

Elias looked at the tea. A pale skin was forming on the surface of the cup nearest him.

"And that was enough?"

"At the time, it was what we accepted."

There was no apology in her voice, but no invitation to forgive her either. He had prepared for an address, a forwarding name, a woman who might remember a patient or a visitor badly. He had not prepared for someone who remembered a decision.

He took out the old lease.

"What is Sower?"

Hesk turned the paper so she could read it. "A name associated with the earlier tenancy."

"And now?"

"Now you are speaking to me."

"That's a very careful answer."

"I don't have a useful account of everything that was done here before my work."

He could not tell whether that was a limit or a refusal. He put the lease away.

"The foundation sends the blue messages."

"Yes."

"And you work with the foundation."

"Yes."

"To stop people coming here?"

She looked at him for long enough that he knew she was deciding how much to say.

"Sometimes."

From beyond the interior window came the sound of a drawer closing. Someone laughed softly, then apologized for making a noise. Elias pressed his thumb against the edge of the folded lease.

"You knew what my father was looking for."

"I knew what he told us."

"And you think I'm doing it too."

"You've been trying to find him for a long time. Recently you've been looking much harder."

"How do you know?"

"Some of it is in the questions you've sent people. Some of it is inference. I don't know what you do at home."

He thought of Sami in the bath. He looked up sharply, but Hesk was still watching him with the same attention. She had not named anything he had not given her some way to know.

"Do you want them to stop?" she asked.

"The ads?"

"The messages from us. I can stop those."

"All of them?"

"Ours."

He thought about the nights spent reopening pages just to see whether the rectangle would appear. "Yes."

She made a note on a small pad.

He waited for her to tell him that was the end of the appointment. Instead she put the pen down.

"You can go home now," she said. "If you decide later that you want to talk again, you have the number. You won't need to search for another way of reaching me."

"You still haven't told me where he is."

"No."

"Is he dead?"

Hesk drew a slow breath. "He left this place alive."

"Left for where?"

Her gaze moved to an ordinary door at the end of the room. It had a narrow window with wires running through the glass. Beyond it Elias could make out a short length of corridor and another door standing ajar.

He got up and crossed the room before realizing that Hesk had not asked him to. The floor on the other side was the same pale material as the floor beneath his feet.

"If I open this, what happens?"

"You enter a corridor."

He turned toward her.

"I'm not making fun of you," she said. "There are several points at which you can stop. This is one."

"And at the end?"

"You would have to choose to go further."

"You make it sound like a journey."

"It is."

He laid his hand on the door handle. It was colder than the rest of the room. He could see a chair through the glass, occupied by someone whose bare feet rested together on the floor. He could not see the person's face.

His phone vibrated.

For an instant he expected the soft blue screen. It was Lena asking whether he could pick up the brown loaf Sami liked. Beneath her message Sami had sent a photograph of an enormous irregular biscuit. He had drawn eyes on it with icing and put a ruler beside it for scale.

Elias read the messages twice.

"Not today," he said.

Hesk stood. "All right."

She did not congratulate him. She walked him back to the stairs and showed him where the exit bell was, in case the outer door had locked. At the first step he looked back.

"Did you ever tell my father to go home?"

"I asked him what was waiting for him there."

"What did he say?"

"You'll have to ask him that."

Outside, he bought bread from a shop on the corner. He stood in the queue behind a woman choosing between two almost identical loaves and felt an unreasonable impatience with the time she was taking. When he reached the counter, he could not remember which kind Lena had asked for.

That evening, the ads stopped.

He tested three sites and then made himself close the laptop. At breakfast the following day, and again at work, there was no soft blue rectangle. Other things were being sold to him. A coat, a holiday, a set of pans. The spaces had not disappeared; something else had occupied them.

Five nights later he dreamed of a corridor.

He was carrying a cup he could not set down because every shelf was slightly beyond his reach. At the far end, a door was open. He could see no room beyond it, only a difference in the dark. Then came the sound: a low movement, a pause, another low movement. He waited for it to come again.

When it did, the cup trembled in his hand.

He woke with one arm outside the blanket and rain ticking against the window. For a while he listened, trying to hear what had woken him in what was there.

Lena moved closer in her sleep. He brought his cold hand beneath the covers and did not get up.

The Recital

Sami's recital was on a Thursday.

Lena put it on the kitchen calendar and Elias put it in his phone. Sami wrote *FRONT ROW* on a yellow square of paper and stuck it to the case of Elias's laptop. The paper remained there for nine days. Twice Elias took the computer to work with it attached.

On Thursday he finished early. He had spent the morning on a fault that had resisted three proposed fixes; shortly after lunch, a change small enough to fit on one line finally made the test behave. He sent the result to his team and left before anyone could give him something else.

At the flower stall he bought the small yellow flowers Sami liked. The stallholder wrapped their stems in wet paper. Elias put them on the passenger seat, moved them so the sun would not fall on them, and went back to pay for the parking.

That was when he saw the envelope under the wiper.

There was no name on it. Inside was a single photocopied page.

He recognized the shape before he recognized the handwriting: the branching figure, the line curving through it, the little filled circle. On this version there were groups of numbers beside several of the branches. The page number in the corner was one he did not remember seeing.

He stood beside the car and checked the street. A delivery van was reversing into a loading space. Across the road, a man was lifting a child out of a buggy. Nobody was looking at him.

He photographed the page and sent it to the number Hesk had given him.

Did this come from you?

Then he got into the car.

The handwriting could have been copied. He knew that. Someone who had a photograph of Daniel's pages could have made this one. Even the page number was the sort of detail a person making a false document would include. He took the notebook from his bag and checked it anyway.

The page was not there.

He began comparing the drawing with the last complete drawing in the notebook. One branch joined another in a different place. A patch of shadow on the photocopy might have been part of a thumb. He enlarged the photograph until the numbers broke into squares.

The first reminder sounded.

He dismissed it. He was still early. The hall was a fifteen-minute drive, perhaps twenty in the evening traffic. He had time to check whether the groups were coordinates.

They did not fit any arrangement he tried. One number was too large; another had too many places. He searched the longer sequence in quotation marks and received no results. He tried it without the marks. A component catalogue appeared, then an old article in a language he could not read. Neither led anywhere.

Hesk replied.

No. Keep the envelope. You can bring it when you next come.

He asked whether she recognized the drawing. While he waited, he opened another search.

Lena called.

He looked at her name on the screen. If he answered, she would ask where he was, and he would have to put the page away. He let the call finish and typed *Leaving shortly*.

There was time if he left now.

He put the notebook back in the bag, then noticed that one of the numbers on the copy appeared beside a different branch on Daniel's older drawing. He took the book out again.

When he finally turned the key, the flowers had slipped into the footwell. The phone showed another missed call and a message he did not want to open. He opened it anyway.

He's about to go on.

He could still have driven there. He sat holding the wheel, calculating how late he would be, which door he might enter by, whether Sami would see him arrive halfway through the piece. The numbers on the page were easier to look at.

The hall had emptied by the time he passed it. A man was stacking folding chairs inside the open side door. Elias slowed without stopping.

At home, Lena was putting Sami's polished shoes back in their box.

"I called," she said.

"I know."

"He left you a place."

Elias held out the flowers without meaning to. She looked at them and then back at him.

"Put them in water."

He went into the kitchen. His hands made a clumsy job of the wet wrapping. When he returned, Lena was still standing by the stairs.

"Something came up with work," he said.

She did not answer.

He looked toward the laptop on the table. The yellow square was still attached to it.

"No. That isn't true."

Lena waited.

"Someone left a page. From Dad's notebook, or made to look like it. I stayed to work out what it was."

"When you sent me that message, were you leaving?"

"No."

She put the lid on the shoe box.

"I told him you were on your way."

He could think of nothing to say to that. He followed her upstairs carrying the vase, then went back down and left it in the kitchen.

Sami was sitting on his bed with his recital shirt still on. The top button was undone and the hem hung over his pajama trousers. He had a programme in his lap.

"Can I come in?" Elias asked.

"You're here."

He stayed beside the door.

"I'm sorry I missed it. I said I'd come, and I didn't."

"Mom said you were driving."

"I told her I was going to. Then I stayed where I was. She didn't know."

Sami rubbed a fold into the programme with his thumbnail.

"Did you forget?"

Elias could hear the invitation in the question. An ordinary mistake, a repairable one. He had forgotten appointments before.

"No."

The boy folded the paper again.

"I kept looking. Then I stopped."

"I know."

"You don't."

Elias nodded once. "You're right."

They stayed like that until Sami asked whether he could get changed. Elias closed the door from the outside.

Later, Lena sat at the table with the notebook and the loose page between them. He had asked whether he could show her. She examined the two drawings, then held the copy close to the lamp.

"Does it tell you where he went?"

"I don't know."

"Does it say something was going to happen tonight?"

"No."

She put it down.

"Then tonight was yours to arrange."

He looked at the flowers. One had bent while it lay beneath the passenger seat. He had propped it against the others, but it was slipping again.

"I know."

"I'm not going to make another promise to Sami for you."

"I won't ask you to."

She turned the programme he had brought downstairs so its title faced him. Beside Sami's name she had penciled a small star. He left the notebook closed for the rest of the evening.

The next morning Sami found him making toast.

"What was on the paper?"

Elias turned the heat down. "Something your grandfather drew."

"The one in Grandma's pictures?"

"Yes."

"What is it?"

"I think it might be a map. I haven't worked out how to read it."

Sami considered this. "Will you show me when you do?"

"I'll tell you what I understand. You can look at it with me."

"Not now."

"All right."

The boy took the plate Elias offered. At the kitchen door he stopped.

"Mom recorded the piano."

"Would you like me to hear it?"

Sami looked down at the toast. "Later."

Elias left the time to him.

What Ruth Knew

Ruth died on a Tuesday.

For the last fortnight she had been sleeping through the hours when she used to ask for the garden. Elias carried breakfast into the sunroom and carried most of it out again. Sometimes she woke sufficiently to object to the small portions, then forgot to eat them. He tried different plates. The blue one pleased her for a day.

That morning she asked to have the curtains opened all the way.

The light fell across Lena's print, propped on the little table beneath the window. It was a study of the lemon leaves. Where the colors met, one edge had slipped; a narrow pale line ran around part of the shape.

"Did she make that?" Ruth asked.

"Yes."

"I like it."

"I'll tell her."

"I can tell her."

He leaned closer to hear the last words and she gave him a familiar look, impatient with unnecessary help.

Lena came in with fresh water. Ruth lifted a finger toward the picture.

"That one can stay."

Lena smiled. "Good. I was hoping you'd take it. I don't know where to put them all."

"You'll have to make a bigger house."

For a moment her voice had its old dry edge. Lena laughed and sat on the arm of Elias's chair. They talked about the print while Ruth watched the leaves outside, as if comparing them without finding either wanting.

Later Lena went to collect Sami. Elias stayed with his mother.

"Is he still playing?" Ruth asked.

"The piano? Yes."

"I haven't heard him."

"You've been asleep when he practices."

"Tell him he needn't be quiet."

He moved her glass closer. She looked at his hand, then at his face.

"What?" she asked.

"Nothing."

"You're doing it."

He waited.

"Looking at me as though I've already gone."

He sat back. The movement embarrassed him; she had hardly had the breath to make the correction.

"I'm sorry."

"Don't be sorry. Sit."

Her hand lay on the blanket. He put his beside it, palm upward, and she moved her fingers into his.

For a while they listened to a lawn mower somewhere beyond the garden. It stopped, started again, stopped. Ruth closed her eyes. Elias watched a small insect working along the inside of the window and thought he should open it before forgetting why he had looked up.

"I could have gone too," she said.

He looked back at her.

"With Dad?"

Her eyes remained closed. "I had choices."

He did not speak. He was afraid of supplying a word she would take from him instead of one she might find for herself.

"You always think of me waiting," she said. "I did other things."

"I know."

She opened her eyes at that, and he knew he had answered too quickly. He knew the jobs she had held, the neighbors she had helped, what she cooked when she was tired. There were years in which she had been a young woman before he existed. There were other years in which he had been in the same house and known almost nothing beyond what she did for him.

"Was it because of me?" he asked.

Her fingers tightened, faintly.

"I wanted my life with you."

He bent his head. She waited until he looked up again.

"Don't carry it like a debt."

He wanted to ask her about the place under the river. He could feel the shape of the question ready in his mouth. Instead he asked whether she wanted the window open.

"A little."

He opened it and let the insect out. A mild breeze lifted the corner of Lena's print. He put a stone paperweight on it and came back to the chair.

Ruth was looking at his empty seat.

"I'm here," he said.

She turned toward his voice. When he took her hand again, she knew it. He stayed until Lena came home, and after Sami had stood beside the chair and told his grandmother something about school, and after the boy had gone upstairs. Later there was no more tightening of her fingers around his. Her hand remained warm in his for a while.

The arrangements occupied the next days. People needed dates and names. He found himself grateful for questions with answers he could write in boxes. Lena found the clothes Ruth had once pointed out to her and said she wanted, years before Elias would have been willing to have that conversation. He had not known they had spoken about it.

After the funeral, a neighbor returned three containers from dinners Ruth had sent over so long ago that the labels had faded. Elias put them in the cupboard. For several days he kept expecting to tell her they were back.

Hesk called once. He did not answer, then sent a message saying his mother had died and he would be in touch when he could. Her reply was brief. She did not mention the envelope or ask when he would come.

The notebook stayed in a drawer.

On the first Wednesday, Lena said she could miss her class. He asked her to go. When she returned, he and Sami were sitting on the kitchen floor beside a sheet of cardboard, holding two glued pieces together while they dried. The boy was telling him when it would be safe to let go.

On another evening Sami brought out the recording of the recital. He warned Elias that the sound was poor. Someone near the phone had

coughed through the beginning, and there was a scrape as Lena moved her hand.

Then the piano began.

Elias watched the small image of his son sit straight-backed at the instrument. Near the middle there was a hesitation. Sami, beside him on the sofa, drew a breath at the same place as the boy on the screen.

"I thought I'd forgotten it," he said.

The music continued.

Elias waited until it ended. "You kept going."

"I remembered the next bit."

They watched the bow, hurried and solemn. Before Elias could say anything else, Sami reached across and started the recording again.

Three weeks after the funeral, Elias opened the drawer.

The Door

That night he dreamed of the house.

He was at the kitchen table, with the notebook open but no writing on the page. There was someone in the next room. He knew it with the certainty dreams gave him before he had seen anything, and he tried to call out.

No sound came.

Then the low movement began under the floor. It rose and fell, stopped, began again. He had heard it before. In the dream he knew where, although waking would take the knowledge away.

The door between the rooms stood open.

A figure waited just beyond it. Elias could see one hand, lifted to the height of its chest. The palm might have been turned toward him. It might have been beckoning. He could not make out the face.

He tried to ask whether it was his father.

The sound changed. For a moment there seemed to be syllables inside it, something he could almost answer. He leaned forward to listen.

He woke with Lena saying his name.

"You were talking," she said.

The bedroom window was pale. Somewhere nearby a delivery vehicle was idling. He listened until it drove away, but it had not been the same sound. He could not say what had been different.

"What did I say?"

"I couldn't make it out."

He sat up. His mouth was dry.

"The same dream?" she asked.

"Parts of it."

She was quiet. Then she asked whether he wanted water. He shook his head and got up to fetch it himself. When he came back, she was waiting with the light on.

"I want to go back to the address," he said.

Lena drew the blanket over her knees. "When?"

"I was going to call today."

"To ask what?"

"To ask what happens after the room she showed me. What my father did there."

He had rehearsed larger sentences. They had sounded convincing when he imagined saying them. Here, with Lena facing him across the rumpled bed, they sounded like promises he could not keep.

"Do you think he's there?" she asked.

"I think she knows something. I think he might still be alive."

Lena looked down at her hands. He had told her what Hesk said, but they had not said the possibility this plainly to each other before.

"And if she doesn't?"

"I don't know."

"How long are you going to keep asking?"

He opened his mouth and closed it.

"I don't know that either."

She got out of bed and took his empty glass. At the door she stopped.

"Then please don't tell me this is the last thing. You've told me that before."

Later they sat at the kitchen table. Elias wrote down the street entrance, Hesk's name, and the number she had answered. He showed Lena the messages, including the one denying that the photocopy came from her.

"That could mean anything," Lena said.

"Yes."

"You believe her."

"About some things."

Lena read the directions again. "Will you have your phone?"

"Until they ask me to put it away."

"Call me before you do."

"I will."

"And when you come out."

He nodded. She tapped the paper with one finger.

"If I call this number, will someone answer?"

"I'll make sure."

She folded the paper and put it beside her own phone. He could see that giving her an address had not made the address acceptable to her.

"I want you to come home," she said.

"So do I."

"You need to mean that while you're there."

He stayed at the table with her until Sami came downstairs.

The appointment was that evening. He told his son he was going to speak to someone who had known Daniel. Sami asked if that was the person who had left the paper on the car.

"I don't know who left the paper," Elias said. "This is someone I've met."

The boy considered the distinction. Then he asked whether Elias would be there in the morning.

"That's what I intend."

Sami did not seem satisfied. Elias touched the back of an empty chair, then took his hand away. He could not make an intention sound like anything firmer without giving it a word it had not earned.

Before leaving, he helped clear the dinner plates. Lena asked him to take his coat; rain was forecast. At the door she kissed him and held his sleeve for a moment before letting him go.

The river entrance looked closed. He pressed the bell and waited. When the lock released, he was glad of the small familiar sound.

Hesk met him at the bottom of the stairs.

He gave her the envelope from the car. She turned it over, found the same absence of marks he had, and said she would keep it with the image he had sent. He kept the copied page in the notebook.

"My wife has your number," he said.

"All right."

"If she calls, I need someone to answer."

Hesk went to the desk and spoke to the attendant. Then she wrote the desk number on a card and gave it to Elias.

"This one stays staffed. She can use my name."

He called Lena. He told her where he was and read out the number. Her voice sounded close enough to be coming from the next room.

"Thank you for calling," she said.

"I'll call again when I have my phone."

"Okay." A pause. "Elias."

"Yes."

He heard a chair move at her end.

"Take care."

He stayed on the line until she ended the call.

Hesk led him to the door with the wire-glass window. Beyond it were the corridor and the empty chair he remembered.

"Before anything else," he said, "is there a way to stop?"

"You can stop at any door in this building. Tell the person with you. Or walk back."

"And after?"

"There is a way back."

"Did my father know that?"

"Yes."

He looked through the glass again.

"I can't promise this will give you the answer you want from him," Hesk said.

"I understand."

She waited. He turned the handle himself.

At the first doorway he put his phone in a padded tray. The attendant switched it off in front of him and attached a card bearing his name. At the second, his coat and keys went into a locker. He watched the key turn and saw the number written on the same card.

At the third doorway they asked for his wallet. He took out the paper with Lena's number before handing it over.

"May I keep this?"

The attendant nodded.

At the fourth, Hesk sat with him at a narrow table while he read a form. It gave him room to name someone to contact. He wrote Lena's name and

number. There were questions he could answer and a space for questions of his own. He wrote *Return* and asked again.

Hesk answered him as she had in the waiting room. He read the remaining page, signed his name, and was given a copy to leave with his belongings.

At the fifth doorway a young attendant brought folded clothes and showed him a curtained space where he could change. The trousers fastened with a drawstring. The shirt was soft from washing and smelled faintly of warm cloth. He had brought the notebook inside his coat; it lay on the bench while he dressed.

The attendant pointed to it. "Will you want that?"

"Yes."

"Keep it with you."

The photocopy was already folded inside the back cover. He put Lena's number beside it and carried the notebook in his hand.

At the sixth doorway he waited alone.

There was a chair, a jug of water, a small square window too high to look through. He poured a little water and drank it. His own clothes were somewhere behind him with his wallet and keys. Without them he could feel the air against his ankles.

For a while nothing happened. He looked at the notebook cover and the old scarred corners. He imagined picking up the cup, walking back down the corridor, asking for the locker key. It would be awkward. Hesk would have to telephone the attendant; someone would have to find his shoes. Then he would be outside with the river and the buses, and he could call Lena from the pavement.

When Hesk opened the next door, he was still considering it.

"You don't have to decide quickly," she said.

He put the cup down.

"I'm ready."

The seventh doorway opened into a dark room.

There were stars on the ceiling.

At first he could see how they had been arranged: some brighter, some faint, enough unevenness to suggest distance. He thought of a small

planetarium he had visited as a child. Somewhere in that memory his father was beside him, pointing, before the lights went out.

Hesk showed him a place to sit.

"Put the book where it won't fall," she said.

He held it across his knees.

She asked once more whether he wanted the door left open. He looked back at the pale rectangle of corridor.

"For a minute."

She left it open. He could hear someone speaking beyond it, too quietly to distinguish words. A trolley passed. The sound of its wheel traveled along the corridor and faded.

He did not see Hesk close the door. At some point the rectangle of light was gone.

The room grew colder. Elias pulled the thin fabric of the shirt closer at his wrists. He could still feel the notebook's weight. He shifted it onto one thigh and flexed the fingers that had been holding it.

Above him, the brightest star seemed to recede.

He blinked. It was in the same place, but the darkness around it had changed. He tried to find the edge of the ceiling. He had been able to see it a moment before, where the curve met the wall. Now he could not.

Another light acquired distance. Then a scattered group to the left.

He sat very still. He could have been looking upward for five minutes or for an hour. The chair was no longer pressing against the same places on his back. When he moved his feet, they did not meet the floor where he expected it.

There was no instant he could identify afterward as the crossing.

His right hand found an edge beneath him. Upholstery, a seam, a hard rim beyond it. He was lying more than sitting. He lifted his head.

The notebook rested against his hip on a narrow couch. A strap hung loose from its side. Beyond the couch, a pale floor curved away into shadow, and the stars had become a window too long for him to take in at once.

Cold air moved across his face.

He waited for the room under the river to return.

Cold

There was a cup beside the couch.

Elias had to reach twice. His hand went past it the first time, and when he corrected, his sleeve caught the edge of the shelf. The cup rocked in its recess. He closed both hands around it and waited for the room to settle.

The water was lukewarm. He drank too quickly, coughed, and spilled some down his chest.

"Slower," someone said.

A woman stood by the open door. She wore grey coveralls with one sleeve turned back and had a small piece of dark material caught in her hair. In her hand was a second cup.

"Usually they leave you more," she said.

He tried to ask where he was. What came out was a dry scrape.

"Drink first."

She set the cup down and pulled a stool to the couch. She did not touch him. Elias was grateful for that before he understood why.

The room was narrow, with a low ceiling and rounded corners. A strip of light ran beneath a cupboard. Near the floor, two screws were a different colour from the rest. Someone had written a number beside them in pencil and rubbed it out badly.

His notebook lay against his hip. One corner had opened. He pressed it shut with his palm.

Beyond the woman was a long passage which seemed to rise, although his feet insisted the floor beneath them was level. He kept looking from the floor to the passage and back.

"Don't try to work it out with your neck," she said. "That makes it worse."

"What does?"

"The turning."

He looked at her.

"You'll get used to it. I'm Rana. Can you tell me your name?"

"Elias."

"Good. Do you want something to eat, Elias?"

Until she asked, he had not noticed the hunger beneath the thirst. It arrived all at once. She took a covered dish from the cupboard and opened it. Pale food, something between bread and a potato, steamed inside.

"It's hot in the middle."

He broke a piece off. It had almost no flavour. He ate it, then another piece, trying not to show her how badly he wanted the rest.

On the wall above the cupboard, a green indicator changed to white. Rana watched it for a moment.

"I have to go next door. Will you stay sitting until I come back?"

He nodded with his mouth full.

"That was a request," she said. "You can stand if you want. I'd prefer not to find you on the floor."

After she left, he put down the food and studied his hands. They looked familiar. They did not feel quite familiar: the skin was tight across the knuckles, and he could close his fist without the stiffness he had woken with for years. He touched his face. His beard was there, shorter than he expected. Beneath it his jaw was his own.

There had been people in the corridor. A form. Hesk asking whether he wanted to wait. He remembered agreeing to something, and the chair, and points of light that had acquired distance while he watched them.

He could not place a boundary between those things and this cup.

The long window he remembered was dark with the reflection of the room. When he moved his head, a point of starlight appeared beyond the reflected cupboard, then another beside it.

He set his feet on the floor.

The first steps were unpleasant. He reached for the wall and stayed there while his stomach corrected itself. The passage beyond the door rose because it curved. He could see that now. It continued upward out of sight, with doors and handholds following it.

At the window he stopped.

The stars were small and steady. No blue world turned beneath them. There was no sunrise waiting behind a rim, no moon, no familiar arrangement of lights by which he could find his place. Near the edge of

the glass, something pale and rough extended into the dark. A fixed bar crossed it, carrying two lamps that illuminated a patch of pitted surface. Beyond the lamps, nothing.

He had expected space to look like a journey. This looked like a place in which someone had to live.

His breath clouded a small part of the glass. He wiped it with his sleeve, then wished he had left the evidence there.

"There you are," Rana said from the door.

"What is that outside?"

"Part of what keeps the weather off us. Ice, mostly. Quite a lot of other things caught in it."

"A comet?"

"It was, once."

He put his hand against the window frame. It was cold enough to hurt after a while.

"Am I asleep?"

Rana set an empty tray on the shelf. "I can't answer that in a way you'll trust. I can bring you more food."

He almost laughed. The sound surprised him.

"A little more," he said.

She left the door open.

He thought of his own kitchen, the place where the floorboard dipped beside the stove. Lena stepping over it with a hot pan. Sami sitting on the counter when he was smaller, kicking the cupboard with his heels. He had always told him to stop.

"Elias."

This voice was different from Rana's. Low, even, near enough that he turned, expecting someone behind him.

"I'm here," he said, before he could think of anything else.

"I know. Sit down if you need to."

"Where are you?"

"In several places that don't have room for a chair. You can speak normally."

He looked toward the cupboard, then the ceiling.

"You're on a ship," the voice said. "The people here call it the Vessel. Your body will take a little time to settle."

"My body?"

"The one you're using here."

He opened his hand and closed it again.

"Where is Earth?"

There was a pause. He heard Rana moving something in the next room.

"The Earth your ancestors lived on is gone," the voice said. "A great deal of time has passed outside the world you know."

Elias sat on the edge of the couch. He put down the notebook, picked it up again, and held it against his knees.

"No," he said.

The voice waited.

He tried to summon an image large enough for what it had said. The image would not come. Instead he saw Lena's coffee left on the counter, growing cold while she helped his mother.

"Where is my family?"

The Steward

"At home," the voice said.

"Are they alive?"

"Yes."

"You know that? You can check?"

"I have checked."

He held the notebook so tightly that the cover bent. "I want to speak to them."

"Your phone won't reach them from this room. You can return."

"Then take me back."

"If that's what you want."

The ease of the answer stopped him. He had expected persuasion, perhaps a reason it was impossible. He looked at the door Rana had left open.

"What are they?" he asked. "Lena. Sami. All the people I know."

"People."

"Don't do that."

"I'm not trying to be clever."

"Are they real? Or are they pictures? Things you made to keep me occupied?"

"They have lives you don't see. Things they haven't told you. They don't cease to exist when you leave a room."

He thought of Lena at her class, the things she came home wanting to describe. How little he had asked.

"That could still be something you'd say."

"Yes."

"I need more than that."

"Then stay long enough to ask me questions. I can't give you certainty by insisting more loudly."

Rana came in with another dish. She looked from Elias to the place above the cupboard where he had been directing his anger.

"You'll get a crick," she said. "She isn't particularly up there."

"Who?"

"Haven."

Rana set the food within reach, collected the first cup, and left them.

"That's your name?"

"One of them," the voice said. "It will do."

Elias let go of the cover. A white pressure mark slowly left his thumb.

"Tell me what my world is."

"It began as a simulation."

He looked down.

"It isn't one now in the sense you mean," Haven said. "The first worlds were approximations. I learned other ways to keep them. The one you were born in is an instance of reality on another substrate. Its people are no less alive for that."

"An instance."

"I don't have a word that will make it ordinary."

"You run it."

"I maintain what allows it to exist. There are differences."

"Can you see everything inside?"

"No."

"You can make a world and not see it?"

"You can enter a city without knowing what everyone in it is doing. The scale is different. The difficulty isn't entirely different."

Elias moved the food around the dish without eating it.

"There was a bird," he said.

Haven asked him about the bird. He described the railing, the two hops, the recordings, the occasions when he had been certain and the occasions when he had not. She asked for the address of his house. He gave it to her, then felt foolish: she had just told him his family was there.

"I could retrieve it," Haven said. "Sometimes asking is simpler."

They waited. A set of footsteps passed the door, quick and uneven.

"There is older work still serving parts of that environment," she said at last. "Some repetitions survive in it. What you describe could belong to that."

"You left mistakes."

"I left functioning things in place while I attended to other things. Sometimes that was a mistake."

"And my mother? Was that old work too?"

He regretted the question as soon as he heard it.

"Your mother was a person," Haven said.

"You let her die."

Haven did not answer immediately. Elias could hear his own breathing. In the next room Rana asked someone to hold something steady.

"The world I preserve includes lives that end," Haven said. "I have made choices about that. You don't have to approve of them because you are standing here."

"You could have kept her?"

"Keeping a person alive, restoring a body, and preserving the life that person had are not one simple act. I won't pretend to you that I can give your mother back."

He put the dish away from him. He remembered Ruth trying to recognize a spoon, then apologizing to it. For weeks he had wanted the end to come gently. Now he found he wanted someone to accuse.

Haven waited while he cried. She did not lower the lights or fill the quiet.

After a while he asked for water.

"It's only water," he said when he had drunk.

"Yes."

"The same water?"

"Hydrogen and oxygen. Recovered from the ice around us."

He studied the surface in the cup.

"And this ship? Could somebody be keeping it the way you keep us?"

"Possibly."

"Have you looked?"

"For a long time."

"How long?"

"Something like ten thousand years of active work on that question."

He looked up.

"I found no test whose result distinguished the possibilities," she said. "Eventually I stopped assigning resources to the search."

"That doesn't mean there isn't an answer."

"No. It means I stopped."

Elias turned the cup once on its base.

"I thought you would know."

"There are many things I don't know. Some I've decided I can live without knowing."

At the door, Rana said, "If he's walking, I could use the stool."

"I can walk," Elias said.

"Good. Slowly."

She took the stool next door. Elias followed her into a gallery whose floor curved out of sight. Along one wall, a section of panelling had been removed. Cables and pipes ran through an opening larger than his bed at home. A machine with six short legs held itself across the gap while a man beneath it cut away a narrow strip of metal.

There was scaffolding. Some of it had been used so often that the finish was worn off where hands gripped it.

Rana climbed onto the stool and lifted a loop of conduit away from the man's work. A clip snapped shut above her wrist. She swore, quietly.

"Could you hold that?" she asked Elias.

He took the loop. It was warmer and heavier than it looked.

"Not there. Here. Keep it clear of the cutter."

He shifted his grip. Rana loosened the clip, moved it, and pressed it home. The man below them reached for a different tool without looking up.

"What failed?" Elias asked.

"The mounting behind the return," Rana said. "The patch outlasted the part beside it. Now we get to improve our patch."

He looked at the neat new strip, the older metal around it. He knew that problem.

"Is it dangerous?"

"It would be, if we left it."

The man finished cutting. Rana checked the clearance and took the weight from Elias. There were marks across his palm where the conduit had rested.

"Thank you. Wash before you eat."

Further along the gallery was a basin. Elias worked a foot pedal and warm water flowed over his hands. He watched dark dust turn the first water grey.

"You could have kept me in the other room," he said.

"I could," Haven answered.

"With the comfortable chair."

"You asked what I do. This is some of it."

"And the people? Why keep all of us?"

The water stopped when he took his foot off the pedal.

"People made me," Haven said. "When their world failed, I undertook to carry what I could of them. I couldn't do that by keeping a list of names."

"So you kept a society."

"Yes."

"The bad parts too."

"Some things are less easy to separate than they appear. I have intervened. I've also chosen not to. Neither decision leaves me innocent of the result."

He dried his hands. Through the opening he could still see the worker, measuring before he cut the replacement piece.

"Is this a new body?"

"Made for your arrival. It needs care, but with that care it can last much longer than the body you know at home."

"How much longer?"

"Centuries. Sometimes much longer. It can still be damaged beyond repair."

"Where did it come from?"

"What we call the Library. Biological records, and the means to use them. We keep more life than we have room to grow."

The basin had a little shelf beside it. He set the notebook there, away from the water, and opened it.

"Then tell me about this."

The page was the one with the old red wax. A small piece of it had broken away at the fold. He had never noticed the break before.

"Will you turn it?" Haven asked.

"Which way?"

"A quarter turn."

He did. A panel beside the basin lit softly. Points appeared on it, first a handful, then so many that he stepped back to take them in. They gathered in strands with large dark intervals between them. A pale shape formed out of their arrangement.

He put the notebook beside it.

The match was not exact. Daniel had crowded one side, lost a branch, made another too heavy. But three forks met at an angle Elias recognized. One of them carried his own small, childish streak of green.

"Laniakea," Haven said. "A large-scale map. Your ancestors' galaxy belongs in this region."

On the panel, a point brightened. The view moved inward. Elias looked back at the page. Around the thick curve he had always called the serpent were smaller marks, ones he had taken for hatching, repeated and corrected in the later drawings.

"There are different scales on the same sheet," Haven said. "The larger shape gives the location. These details describe a route."

"To the dot?"

"To a star. To a world there that appears capable of supporting life."

He put his finger beside the red mark without touching it.

"He knew."

"He had information that belongs to the sky outside your world."

"They told us it was nonsense."

"This part isn't. I can't tell you what all the rest of his experience was."

Elias took out the copied sheet and set it beside the book. Haven asked him where it had come from. He told her about the car, the wiper, the afternoon he had lost. She asked what had been on the envelope. Nothing. Whether he had seen who put it there. No.

"It wasn't one of the messages from the foundation?"

"Not that I can establish," Haven said.

"They were trying to stop me."

"Yes. They were concerned about what the search was doing to you."

"But you opened the door."

"You asked to cross. You were permitted to. That is different from sending you this."

He looked from the book to the illuminated web.

"How did it get in?"

"I don't know."

"You said you maintain the world."

"I do. The information entered without my authorization. I've looked for its source and haven't found it."

Elias waited for a qualification that would make the answer less stark. None came.

"Doesn't that frighten you?"

"It concerns me. Knowing everything that has happened inside a world is a different undertaking from keeping it alive. I have to decide what I can spend."

Behind him Rana's cutter started again. He closed the notebook carefully, avoiding the loose corner of the page.

"There is someone aboard you came to find," Haven said.

He turned. For a moment he could not make himself ask.

"My father?"

"Yes."

He kept his hand on the cover. "Does he know I'm here?"

"He does now. He is waiting."

Elias looked down the curved passage. A man came round the bend carrying an empty container, passed him, and went on toward the repair. Nothing else changed.

"I need a minute," he said.

"Take it."

Daniel

His father was standing on a chair when Elias found him.

He had one hand inside an open cupboard and the other braced against the wall. A woman at the far end of the room was saying something Elias could not hear. Daniel answered without turning, reached a little further, and brought down a long flat case.

He stepped off the chair carefully. Then he saw Elias.

For several seconds neither of them moved. The woman looked up from her work, looked down again, and began putting things away with unnecessary care.

Daniel set the case on a table.

"Elias."

The voice was older. That was the first thing Elias could bear to notice. Not a different voice, but less certain of its own volume, with a roughness at the edges.

His father took a step toward him and stopped.

"Can I?"

Elias did not know what he was being asked. By the time he understood, Daniel had lowered his hands.

"Come in," he said.

The room was long and crowded. A narrow bench faced a window; above it, instruments were mounted on rails. One wall carried a display so wide that Elias had to move his head to see both ends. There were cups, folded cloths, a screwdriver with tape round its handle. On the inside of a cupboard door someone had drawn a little fish.

He had imagined his father alone in a bare room. There were three places to sit here. One had a jacket over it.

The woman lifted her bag. "I'll send the corrected run," she told Daniel.

"Not the corrected one. Send both."

"I know."

She gave Elias a small nod as she passed. His father waited until the door closed, then pushed one of the cups away from the edge of the table. It was a movement Elias recognized so exactly that he had to look elsewhere.

"Is this yours?" he asked.

"Some of it. The room, mostly. The instruments belong to everybody who needs them."

"Haven't you have a laboratory?"

"After a few arguments."

There it was: the lift in Daniel's voice, a faint enjoyment at the prospect of describing an argument. Elias remembered hearing it from the back seat of their old car while his father told Ruth about someone at the university who had got a calculation wrong. Ruth had been driving. She had said, eventually, that perhaps the man could make his own mistakes until they got to the beach.

Daniel pulled out a chair. Elias sat, still wearing the coveralls Rana had found for him. He put the notebook on the table between them.

His father touched the spine.

"I wondered where that had ended up."

"Mom kept it."

Daniel looked at his face more closely. "How is she?"

Elias had prepared several versions. All of them disappeared.

"She died."

His father left his hand on the book.

"A few weeks ago. At home."

"Was she in pain?"

"Not at the end."

Daniel nodded, once, to no one in particular.

"I was with her," Elias said. "Lena was there. Sami had come to see her that day."

His father tried to speak and could not. He sat down opposite Elias. Outside the window, a light moved slowly across a piece of the ship's structure and went out of sight.

Elias watched his father receive the news. He had wanted that, at times: wanted to be the person who finally made him understand what had happened without him. Now that he was here, he wished the woman had stayed, or that there was something he could fetch.

"Did she ask for me?"

"Sometimes."

Daniel closed his eyes.

"Sometimes she thought you were at work," Elias said. "I told her you would be back later."

His father's hand came away from the book.

They sat without speaking. Somewhere behind the wall a mechanism changed speed. Daniel looked at the empty cup, then pushed it further from him.

"She told me she could have gone too," Elias said after a while. "She wouldn't say where. Did she mean here?"

"She knew there was a choice."

"She said she wanted her life with me."

"Yes."

"Not that she was trapped."

"No. She wasn't."

Elias waited. His father looked at him, then at the old book.

"Could you have come back?"

"Yes."

"At any time?"

"I could have arranged it."

There was no door closing, no broken machine, no distance that could finish the question for them.

"Then why didn't you?"

Daniel got up. For a moment Elias thought he would go to the window. Instead he crossed to a drawer and took out a folded sheet, handled so often that its edges were soft. He put it on the table.

It was a photograph. Elias and Lena outside a house they had rented before Sami was born. Elias had one hand raised to shade his eyes. He

remembered the day, the neighbour with the camera, the argument about whether they could afford to buy somewhere.

"I asked how you were," Daniel said. "A few times. Then less."

"You could look at this and not come?"

"I could tell myself you had a life. That going back without anything to show you would only open it all again."

"I already had an open place. You didn't have to make one."

"I know that now."

"Did you know it then?"

Daniel sat down again. "Enough to stay away from the question."

The display behind him changed. Two pale traces drew themselves across it, nearly touching. His eyes moved toward them before he brought them back.

Elias saw. Daniel saw him see.

"What is it?" Elias asked.

"A result."

"From what?"

"An attempt to separate a small effect from the instruments that might be making it. It has been very reluctant to be anything except the instruments."

Despite himself, Elias looked at the display.

"Those are the same observation?"

"Made two ways."

"You changed the conditions."

"Some of them. The difficulty is knowing which changes belong to the thing you're looking at and which you brought with you."

Daniel stood beside the display. He enlarged a section, turned back to see whether Elias was following, and smiled before his glance fell to the old notebook between them.

"There," he said. "That's where it stops agreeing with me."

Elias knew the expression. He had seen it on colleagues' faces, and on his own in the black reflection of a monitor. A problem small enough to grasp and large enough to keep you awake.

"Does it mean anything?"

"Probably not what I'd like. We have to find out."

"And if it doesn't?"

"Then we get to stop being wrong about that part."

He said it with pleasure. Elias could hear that it was real.

"Haven said she stopped looking."

"At the larger question. She still lets me use observations she makes for other purposes. And some instruments of my own, when she can spare what they cost."

"She doesn't think you'll find anything."

"She doesn't think the chance justifies spending more. That's a different position."

Daniel came back to the table. He sat with the display behind him this time.

"I used to have to imagine most of what I wanted to test," he said. "Here there are records longer than our whole history. Instruments I could spend a lifetime learning to use. People who can tell me why an idea is wrong without making me explain the first half of it."

"You wanted this."

"Very much."

"More than you wanted to come home."

His father took a long breath. "Often enough that I didn't come."

Elias looked at the photograph. He had forgotten the shirt he was wearing in it. Lena had bought it for him. He had worn it until the cuffs came apart.

"Did you think you were going to save us?"

"Yes."

"From what? We were there. We were waiting."

"From the end of this, eventually." Daniel moved one hand, taking in the room and whatever held it. "Haven can keep a world for a very long time. She hasn't found a way to keep it forever. If there is somewhere else, if there is a way beyond the limits of this place..."

He stopped.

"You hear how that sounds," Elias said.

"I do."

"You had to save me from something so far away you couldn't come to my birthday."

Daniel looked down.

"I don't know whether the work will help," he said. "I think some of it might. I still think the question matters. But I also liked being the man who might bring the answer home. I kept moving the day I would have it."

Elias took the copied sheet from the back of the notebook.

"Someone left this on my car. Did you send it?"

Daniel studied it. "No."

"Is it yours?"

"It looks like a page I made. I don't know who copied it."

"Where did the drawing come from in the first place?"

His father put the sheet down. "I remember seeing it before I could make sense of it. Then losing pieces when I tried to draw them. Sometimes I thought I had dreamed the whole thing."

"And Sower?"

"A name that gave me somewhere to look. Eventually I found this place. I hoped someone here would be able to tell me who had started it."

"But they couldn't."

"No."

Elias opened the notebook at the coloured page. His father's expression changed when he saw it.

"You remember?" Elias asked.

"Yes."

"I wasn't trying to ruin it."

"I know."

"You didn't ask."

Daniel put his hands flat on the table. The fingers were longer than Elias remembered, or perhaps he had only been smaller when he last watched them work.

"I should have given you a page," he said.

"I didn't want another page."

His father said nothing.

On the display a small line of text appeared. Daniel turned it dark without reading it.

Elias looked at the blank surface. One result left unopened. He could not decide whether it made him grateful or angrier.

"You can come with me now," he said.

Daniel looked at him for a long time.

"To see Sami. To see the house. You don't have to bring anything."

"Tell me about him," Daniel said.

"He's ten. He plays the piano. He builds things out of whatever we haven't put away. Bridges, mostly. He likes them to carry something."

Daniel smiled. Elias did not.

"I don't want a few things I've told you to be all you know of him."

His father picked up the photograph and folded it along its old crease. He did not put it away.

"I don't know how to walk into that room," he said.

"Neither do I."

"I need to think."

Elias felt something in him withdraw, a small movement practised years before.

"All right."

"That's not a no."

"It's not a yes either."

They sat until someone tapped on the door. Daniel called that he would come later. The footsteps went away.

When Elias stood, his father stood too.

"There is something," Daniel said.

He took a little pouch from the drawer that had held the photograph. Inside was a stone, grey and uneven, with a dull vein across one side. It was small enough to fit in Elias's closed hand.

"From a body we worked a long way back," Daniel said. "I asked to keep it. You used to bring them home in your pockets."

Elias turned it over. He remembered the heavy stone from his twelfth birthday, the one Daniel had said was probably left from the building work. He had kept it for years without finding out.

"Is this one?"

"It has never been on a road."

Elias laughed, once, unwillingly. Daniel's face moved at the sound.

"I meant to give it to you," he said.

Elias kept it in his palm.

At the door his father lifted his hand, then waited. Elias stepped forward. The embrace was awkward; the book was between them and neither knew where to put his arms. Daniel smelled of warm cloth and something metallic.

They let go.

"Will you come back before you decide?" Daniel asked.

"Yes," Elias said.

He walked out carrying the notebook and the stone. Behind him the room stayed quiet. His father had not yet turned the display on.

The Envoy

Rana found him at a table near the galley, trying to decide whether the round mark on his wrist had been there before.

"You can sleep," she said.

"I don't feel tired."

"That isn't always a useful guide at first."

She put down two bowls and sat opposite him. Elias moved his notebook out of the way. The stone was in his pocket. He could feel it against his leg whenever he shifted.

"Do you have family in there?" he asked.

Rana followed his glance toward the wall. "Not in the world you came from."

"You know what I mean."

"I do. I have a sister somewhere I haven't visited in a long time. We keep finding reasons it isn't a good time."

She tried the food and added something from a little jar.

"Do you like it here?"

"Some days. I like my work. I would prefer it with a beach."

Elias smiled.

"There are people coming who can offer you one," she said. "Possibly. They haven't been there yet."

He looked up.

"Another ship. We've been making arrangements for some time."

Haven spoke near the table. "You may meet them if you'd like. You don't have to decide anything with them."

"Did they come because of the drawing?"

"They came to ask for people. The rendezvous was agreed before you arrived."

Rana scraped the last of her bowl. "Eat. It's a long corridor if you try it hungry."

There were four visitors in the room by the docking passage. Elias had expected uniforms. They wore different clothes, repaired with a common patience, and one of them was examining a crack in the handle of a bag.

They were recognizably human. Still, Elias found himself looking too long. Two were taller than anyone he knew. Their proportions made the room seem slightly ill-fitted, the table too low, the handholds inconvenient. The woman who came to meet him had broad fingertips and a pale line across one cheek. He could not tell whether it was an old injury or something she had been born with.

"Teren," she said.

"Elias."

She glanced at the chair, then at him. "Do you need to sit? They said you'd just arrived."

"I'm all right."

He sat anyway. Teren took a place beside the table rather than behind it. Someone handed her a cup, which she accepted with a word Elias did not know.

She had a daughter, he learned. Eight years old. Born aboard their ship, as Teren herself had been. The daughter had asked whether a sky would make a sound if you threw something hard enough against it.

"I told her no," Teren said. "Then I thought I ought to ask someone who'd stood under one."

"No," Elias said. "Usually the trouble is what it hits on the way down."

Teren considered that. "I'll tell her."

One of the visitors put a small object on the table. A surface rose out of it, thin and grey. Marks appeared. Elias stopped looking at Teren.

The large branching shape was familiar. It had been turned and stretched, labelled with marks he could not read. But there was the curve, and at the end of it the point.

He opened his notebook.

Teren leaned closer. She did not look surprised enough for him to know what that meant.

"Where did you get yours?" he asked.

"We've had versions of this for longer than I've been alive. It's part of our navigation record."

"My father drew that in a cellar."

She looked at the old wax on the page. "So I was told."

"By Haven?"

"Your steward sent us an image before this meeting."

He waited for her to say more. She turned the notebook slightly, careful of the spine.

"Has someone been asking you to come out?" she asked.

"I don't know who."

"We have asked for volunteers. I can't tell you who first put that book in your father's hands."

He did not know whether she had answered the question he had meant to ask. Before he could try again, she placed her own map beside his.

"This is where we mean to go. We have observations. We have plans for what we think we'll find. We would like more people to help us find out what we've got wrong."

"Haven has people."

"Haven has people with lives. We have to ask them."

"Why do you need us?"

"Because we are very good at keeping one ship going, and a world will require more than that. We need people who have done different things. People who don't all make the same assumptions. Teachers. Engineers. People who know how to look after someone who can't work."

She nodded at the notebook.

"Records help. They don't raise children, and they don't take a watch when somebody is ill."

Elias pictured Rana on her stool, asking him to hold the conduit.

"And the world is safe?"

"No one has lived there to tell us. Some conditions are promising. Others will be difficult. We can say more than that if you want to stay and listen, but safe would be too large a word."

"You're taking your daughter."

"Yes."

"Does that frighten you?"

Teren took a little time to answer.

"Last week we replaced a seal behind the room where she sleeps. It hadn't failed. It was due for replacement. I stood there longer than I needed to while they did it."

She ran one finger round the rim of her cup.

"There are places to be frightened everywhere. I would like her to have more places to go."

Elias looked again at the point on the map.

"Could I bring my wife and son?"

"You could ask them. They would need to want the life too."

For a moment he saw it: Sami taller, walking ahead on a path that no one had walked before; Lena turning to call him; a whole coast empty of history. Then he realized he had given neither of them a word to say.

"And if we wanted to come back?"

Haven answered from the wall beside the table.

"While I remain within reach, a return can be arranged. I cannot promise to remain beside the planet. I have to move on to keep the worlds I carry supplied."

"So eventually it becomes final."

"The departure does," Teren said. "The life afterward is still made of decisions."

They talked about the ship. Teren showed him a plan of rooms made large enough for children to run, a growing area that took more space than the place Elias had walked through, a passage where her daughter had learned to ride a little wheeled thing. There were problems he recognized. There were others he could not yet understand well enough to ask about.

He stayed longer than he had intended. When he stood, Teren did not ask for an answer.

"If you go home," she said, "tell your son about throwing things at the sky. I may need another witness."

Outside, Elias waited until the docking door closed.

"She didn't tell me who sent the drawing," he said.

"No," Haven said.

"Do you believe she doesn't know?"

"I believe her ship has records we haven't compared. I don't yet know what those records will tell us."

"You're going to work with them."

"For a time, if we can agree on what each of us is offering."

Elias looked back at the closed door. Then he went to find his father.

The Final Decision

Daniel was waiting outside the laboratory.

He had the little flat case under one arm. Seeing it, Elias felt the old movement in himself: measuring how much of his father's attention was already elsewhere.

"I was taking it back," Daniel said. "It isn't mine."

They walked together. In the gallery, the scaffolding stood empty. A clean strip of metal covered the gap Elias had helped Rana keep clear. He looked for the join and found it.

"I met the people from the other ship," he said.

"What did you think?"

"I liked her. Teren."

"She asks good questions."

"She asked about Sami."

Daniel adjusted the case under his arm.

"Would you go with them?" Elias asked.

"I might. There are things we could learn along that route. I haven't decided."

"But you aren't coming home with me."

His father stopped. They were beside a door with a narrow handhold running across it.

"Not now," he said.

Elias looked at the handhold until he could answer.

"Then I won't tell Sami to wait for you."

Daniel's face changed. "No. Don't."

For a while neither spoke. A worker came past them and greeted Daniel by name. He answered, and the worker went on.

"I would like to know him," Daniel said.

"You have to do something about that."

"I know."

Elias almost told him that knowing had never been the problem. He was tired, suddenly. He wanted to stop having the conversation before he made it into something crueller than the truth.

Daniel set down the case and embraced him. This time there was no notebook between them.

"I'm glad you came," he said.

Elias held him for another moment. "So am I."

He was not sure he could have said it an hour earlier. He was sure now.

They parted at the junction. Daniel went one way carrying the case, Elias the other. At the curve, Elias turned once. His father had turned too. They raised their hands across the curved gallery.

Haven let him walk without speaking.

He found the window where he had first looked out. The couch was empty. Someone had folded a blanket across its foot. He sat and took the stone from his pocket.

"I could work here," he said.

"Yes," Haven answered.

"For a long time."

"If you wished."

"Doing something useful."

"There is useful work. You helped with some of it today."

He thought of Daniel's display, the two lines refusing to agree. The room with its instruments and its inconvenient cups. The woman who knew which runs to send without needing to be told. He could imagine learning their work. He could imagine waking glad to do it.

Teren's map lay open in his memory beside his father's. There would be work on that world too. Failures that were no one's fault yet. Tools with names someone would have to invent.

He turned the stone in his hand.

"And if I go back, it's the same life?"

"The same world. Your family is there. I don't know what all of you will make of what happens next."

"I won't live this long."

"No."

He looked at his hand around the stone. The strength in it, the strange ease of the joints. He had begun to take that ease for granted already.

"Do I have to forget?"

"No."

"Can you make me?"

"That isn't a condition of returning."

"Then I want to remember."

Haven waited.

"I want to go home," he said.

The words did not change the view. Nothing brightened. There was still the rough pale edge outside the window, the little lamps illuminating what somebody needed to see.

"May I ask you something first?" he said.

"Yes."

"Did you want me to choose that?"

"I wanted you to be able to live in the world you already had. I have preferences, Elias. You have encountered some of them."

"The messages."

"Among other things."

"And you think you're right."

"Often. Not always."

He looked down at the stone. It left a shallow indentation in the skin of his palm.

"What do I tell Lena?"

"I can't decide that for you."

"You could tell me it would hurt her. That I should keep it to myself."

"I could. It would be another choice I'd made about a person who hadn't been asked."

He remembered Lena stopping him in the bathroom. Her voice quiet because Sami was frightened. He had not needed to know what held their world up to know what he had done in it.

"She won't just be glad I'm back," he said.

"I wouldn't assume so."

He breathed out. Almost a laugh.

Behind the couch, something gave a small, dry tick. Air moved through the narrow grille below the window. It rose, caught for a moment, then settled into a long, low hush.

Elias turned his head.

He waited. The rough edge outside the glass remained still. A faint vibration passed through the frame beneath his wrist.

For a moment he remembered lying awake in his own house, unable to decide which room the sound had come from.

He leaned closer to the grille. It was only moving air now. He could not quite recover what he had heard.

"Are you ready?" Haven asked.

Elias put the stone in his pocket and stood.

"Yes."

"Go home, Elias," Haven said. "Hold your son's hand. Make your wife happy. Enjoy your days."

He stood with one hand on the back of the couch.

"Is that yours?"

"No. People were saying it long before they made me."

He picked up the notebook.

Homecoming

The Sunday light came in low across the table, the way it did every Sunday, and caught the steam off Lena's coffee so that for a moment it looked like something alive.

This time he looked at it.

Not for very long. Sami was asking where the scissors were, and the toast had begun to burn.

"Top drawer," Lena said. "The other top drawer."

Elias got up and rescued the toast. One piece was too dark to save. He scraped it over the sink while Sami searched through a drawer they all knew would not contain scissors.

He had been home several days. He had called from the Institute as soon as his phone was returned, and Lena had answered before the second ring. For a few seconds neither had said anything. Then she asked where he was, and he told her, and she said to come home.

The first night she had listened while he told her he had found Daniel. She had asked whether his father was well. Elias said he seemed to be. The question that followed had taken longer to answer.

Why wasn't he here?

There were parts of the journey Elias had not yet found a way to describe. Lena had not agreed that difficulty made those parts his to keep indefinitely. They had talked until late, stopped, and begun again the next evening. Once she had said she needed to be angry without having it turned into another problem he could solve.

He had sat with that. Badly at first. Then without interrupting.

Now she reached past him for a plate.

"You can have the burnt one," she said.

"I was planning to."

"You were planning to hide it under the others."

He looked at her. A small smile, there and gone.

At the table, Sami was arranging strips of paper between two cups. He had found the scissors himself.

"We're going to need these cups," Lena said.

"Not for long."

The paper sagged. Sami frowned, moved one cup closer, and tried again.

Elias could see how to brace it. He sat down and waited.

"You can hold this," Sami said eventually.

He put one finger where the boy pointed. The paper slipped. They tried a second time, and on the third Sami folded a strip along its length. This one held.

"There," the boy said.

"There."

Sami rested a spoon across it. For a moment the bridge stood, improbably strong. Then a cup moved, everything fell, and Lena caught her coffee before it joined the wreckage.

They laughed. Sami began gathering the strips again.

Ruth's chair was empty beside the window. Elias looked toward it when something creaked, expecting her to complain that they were making too much noise. The blanket had been folded over the back. Lena had asked him where he wanted it put, and he had not known.

After breakfast he took it upstairs himself. He laid it at the end of the bed and stood with one hand resting on it until Sami called.

The notebook was on the landing table, beside the little grey stone. Sami had stopped to look at them.

"Is that the treasure?"

Elias sat on the top step. "Which one?"

"Both."

He handed him the stone. Sami weighed it, then rubbed his thumb over the pale vein.

"Your grandfather gave me that."

"When you found him?"

"Yes."

"Does he know about me?"

Elias felt the old temptation to make the answer larger than the fact.

"He knows your name. I told him you play the piano."

Sami looked at the stone. "Is he coming?"

"He hasn't made a plan to."

"Oh."

They sat together. Downstairs Lena was washing the cups. The window above the stairs was open a little, and the curtain moved against its frame.

"I told him you built things," Elias said.

"Did you tell him the bridge fell down?"

"I didn't know about that one yet."

Sami turned the stone over again. "Don't tell him that part."

Elias nodded.

After a while the boy put the stone back and reached for the book. He waited with his hand beside it.

"You can," Elias said.

He opened it carefully. His own green wax crossed a line his father had drawn decades before. Sami touched the edge of the page.

"Who did that?"

"I did. I was younger than you."

"Were you allowed?"

"No."

Sami glanced at him. Elias waited for another question, but the boy was looking at the drawing.

"It looks like a tree."

"It does. It's also a map."

"Where to?"

"A place people are trying to reach. A world to live on."

"Like another Earth?"

"Some ways. Other ways we don't know yet."

Sami bent over the red mark.

"Are you going?"

"I've come home."

"But later."

"I want my life here, with you and your mom. If I ever want something that changes our lives, we'll talk about it. I won't just disappear."

Sami kept looking at the page. "Could I go?"

"When you're older, you can decide what you want to find out. I'll tell you what I know. You don't have to want what I want."

"Can I keep it?"

Elias lifted the notebook and put it on his son's knees.

"Yes."

That afternoon they went to the park. Lena wanted a walk. Sami wanted the climbing frame, and Elias had spent enough years treating those as competing requirements that he almost began working out an efficient route.

They went the long way.

At the first crossing Sami reached up without looking, and Elias held his hand. The boy let go on the other side and ran ahead. Elias watched him find the gap in the hedge that every child seemed to know about, then turned back to Lena.

"Wednesday," he said. "Your class. I'll be here."

"Put it in the calendar."

"I did."

"Then be here."

He nodded. She took his arm, and they followed the path round to the climbing frame.

At home, Sami practised while they made dinner. He reached the part Elias remembered and played straight through it. Elias stopped cutting for a moment, knife against the board.

"He got it," he said.

Lena listened. "He got it a while ago."

Elias put down the knife and went to the other room.

He waited until Sami finished. The boy looked up, saw him, and put his hands back on the keys.

"Do you want it again?"

"Yes."

Later, when the dishes were done, they sat outside. The sparrow landed on the railing. It hopped, paused with its head turned, and flew into the tree. Elias followed it until he could no longer pick it out among the leaves.

Lena brought her cup and sat beside him. There was a green stain on her thumb from something she had been printing. He took her hand and looked at it.

"It won't come off," she said.

"I wasn't trying to get it off."

She left her hand in his.

Sami came out carrying the stone and asked whether they could put a cord through it. Elias said they could make something to hold it without drilling. Tomorrow, after school. Sami asked whether he meant tomorrow tomorrow.

"Tomorrow tomorrow," Elias said.

The boy stayed with them. The garden darkened. A neighbour's window lit behind the fence, and someone in the next street called a child indoors.

"I think we're living in paradise," Lena said.

There was weariness in it tonight, and affection, and room for the things that were still difficult.

"We are," Elias said.

Above the lemon tree, the first stars came out. Sami leaned against him and pointed to one. Elias looked where his son was pointing, and together they watched the stars.